

Word family: **primary / primarily / primary school / primary care / primary source**

Base word: primary

Related form: primarily

Part of speech: adjective (形容詞) / noun (名詞 , 在部分專門用法中)

Your sentence:

> “My favourite childhood friend was a boy called Ryan, who was my classmate in **primary school**.”

Meaning in this passage

Here, **primary** means **relating to the first stage of formal education for children before secondary school**.

繁體中文 : ** **屬於兒童正式教育最初階段、在中學教育之前的小學階段

**中文翻譯 : **

> “...my classmate in **primary school**.”

「.....他是我**小學**時的同班同學。」

Here:

primary school = 小學 ; 兒童接受中學教育之前的基礎學校階段

1. **primary = first in importance (重要性) — 主要的 ; 首要的**

This is one of the main general meanings.

Meaning: More important than other things; the main or most important one.

Practice 1

> “Our **primary** concern is safety.”

「我們最**首要的**考慮是安全。」

Practice 2

> “The **primary** reason for the delay was bad weather.”

「延誤的**主要**原因是天氣惡劣。」

****primary** = 在多個因素、目的、原因或考慮之中最重要、最主要的

Common:

- * primary reason
- * primary concern
- * primary goal
- * primary purpose
- * primary responsibility

These belong to one ****main/most important**** sense.

2. ****primary** = first in order/stage (次序 / 階段) — 最初的 ; 第一階段的

****Primary**** can mean belonging to the first stage of a process, system, or sequence.

Practice 3

> “The disease is still in its ****primary**** stage.”

「疾病仍處於****初期 / 第一階段****。」

Practice 4

> “The ****primary**** phase of the project focused on research.”

「這個項目的****第一階段****主要集中於研究。」

****primary** = 在發展、程序或次序上屬於最初或第一階段的

This is distinct from “most important.” Something can be first in sequence without being the most important.

3. ****primary school / primary education** (教育) — 小學的 ; 初等教育的

This is the meaning used in your passage.

****Meaning:**** Relating to the first formal stage of children's education before secondary education.

Practice 5 — Original

> “Ryan was my classmate in **primary school**.”

「Ryan 是我**小學**時的同班同學。」

Practice 6

> “She teaches at a local **primary school**.”

「她在一間本地**小學**任教。」

Practice 7

> “Children usually begin **primary education** at a young age.”

「兒童通常在年幼時開始接受**小學 / 初等教育**。」

primary school/education = 中學之前的兒童基礎正式教育階段

This is an established educational domain meaning.

4. **primary** = basic/fundamental (基礎 / 根本) — 基本的 ; 首要基礎的

In some contexts, **primary** means fundamental or forming the basic level on which later things depend.

Practice 8

> “Food and shelter are **primary needs**.”

「食物和住所是**最基本 / 首要的需要**。」

Practice 9

> “The course introduces the **primary principles** of design.”

「這門課介紹設計的**基本原則**。」

primary = 構成某個系統、需求或知識的基本而核心部分

This overlaps somewhat with “main/important,” but the focus here is **fundamental/basic**, not ranking among alternatives.

5. **primary** = original/direct source (來源) — 第一手的 ; 原始的

A very important academic/research use:

Practice 10

> “Letters and diaries can be useful **primary sources**.”

「信件和日記可以是很有用的**第一手 / 原始資料來源**。」

Practice 11

> “The researcher examined **primary evidence** from the period.”

「研究員檢視了該時期的**第一手證據 / 原始資料**。」

primary source/evidence = 直接來自事件、時期、人物或原始資料本身，而不是經後人整理或評論的資料

This is genuinely distinct and highly useful for learners.

6. **primary** = main/first provider or point of contact (主要服務 / 醫療) — 初級的 ; 主要的

In healthcare, **primary care** means first-contact, general healthcare rather than specialist care.

Practice 12

> “Most patients first see a **primary care** doctor.”

「大部分病人首先會看**基層醫療 / 家庭醫療**醫生。」

Practice 13

> “The clinic provides **primary care** services.”

「這間診所提供**基層醫療服務**。」

primary care = 病人最先接觸、處理一般健康問題並作初步評估的醫療服務

This is a domain-specific extension based on **first level / first point of contact**.

7. **primary** = basic colour (顏色) — 原色的 ; 基本色的

In art/design/science contexts:

Practice 14

> “Red, blue, and yellow are traditionally taught as **primary colours** in art.”

「在傳統美術教學中，紅、藍、黃常被視為**原色**。」

Practice 15

> “The design uses bright **primary colours**.”

「這個設計使用鮮明的**原色**。」

primary colour = 不能由其他顏色混合而成、並可用來組合出其他顏色的基本色之一

The exact set depends on the colour model, so the concept is domain-specific rather than universally one fixed trio.

Related form: **primarily**

Primarily means mainly or chiefly.

Practice 16

> “The course is **primarily** designed for beginners.”

「這門課**主要**為初學者而設。」

Practice 17

> “The area is **primarily** residential.”

「這個地區**主要**是住宅區。」

primarily = 主要地 ; 以某件事情為主

This directly develops from the **main/most important** sense.

Important distinction: **primary** vs **main**

These often overlap.

****primary****

can mean:

- * most important
- * first in order
- * basic/fundamental
- * first-level

****main****

mainly means:

> the most important or central

So:

> ****primary reason**** $\approx$ main reason

but:

> ****primary school****

cannot normally become:

> ****main school****

Same word family, different grammatical/domain behaviour.

Important distinction: ****primary vs secondary****

This is one of the key contrasts.

****primary****

can mean:

- * first
- * main
- * basic
- * direct/original

secondary

can mean:

- * second in order
- * less important
- * derived rather than original

Examples:

- > primary education ↔ secondary education
- > primary source ↔ secondary source
- > primary concern ↔ secondary concern

So the contrast changes slightly by domain.

Important distinction: **primary source vs secondary source**

primary source

= direct/original evidence from the time, event, person, experiment, etc.

secondary source

= later analysis, interpretation, summary, or discussion of primary material

For example:

- > diary = primary source
- > history textbook = secondary source

This is a very useful academic distinction.

Important distinction: **primary school vs elementary school**

primary school

is common in British and many international education systems.

elementary school

is common in American English.

The exact age range and structure vary by country, so they are broadly corresponding terms rather than perfectly identical worldwide.

Family-extension note

The practical modern family includes:

* **primary**

* **primarily**

Useful compounds include:

* primary school

* primary education

* primary reason

* primary concern

* primary source

* primary care

* primary colour

The important point is that many of these are not random collocations: **primary** repeatedly develops from two broad ideas:

1. **first**

2. **main/fundamental**

The Golden Manual says established academic, educational, medical, and other modern domain uses should be checked, while overlapping uses should still be merged where the same underlying concept works.

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
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primary — most important	在多個原因、目的、責任或考慮之中最主要、最重要的
primary — first in order/stage	在發展、程序或次序上屬於最初或第一階段的
primary school/education	屬於兒童在中學之前接受的第一階段正式教育；小學 / 初等教育的
primary — fundamental/basic	構成某個系統、需求或知識的基本、核心部分

primary source/evidence	直接來自事件、人物、時期或原始材料本身的第一手資料	
primary care	病人最先接觸、處理一般健康問題的基層 / 第一線醫療服務	
primary colour	在特定色彩系統中作為基本來源、用來組合其他顏色的基本色	
primarily	主要地；以某件事情為主	

For your original sentence

> "...my classmate in **primary school**."

The exact meaning is:

primary = 屬於兒童正式教育最初階段、在中學之前的

So:

> **primary school**

= **小學**

For your database, I would count **5 genuinely useful core meanings** for **primary**:

1. **main / most important**
2. **first in order or stage**
3. **fundamental/basic**
4. **direct/original — primary source/evidence**
5. **domain-specific first-level uses such as primary education / primary care / primary colours**

I would keep **primary school, primary care, primary source, primary colour** explicit in the entry because they are high-value domain uses, but avoid inflating each one into an unrelated core meaning when they clearly develop from the broader ideas of **first** or **fundamental**.